

Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness — Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · YouTube Talks · 27:57

Good evening. I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I do hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sambha Sambhudassa Namō tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sambha Sambhudassa — homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So we're making our way through the discourse on how to establish right mindfulness. Now the one in the middle-length sayings, the Majjhima Nikāya, that doesn't have the fullness of the Four Noble Truths. For that, I've had to go to another book called The Long Discourses of the Buddha, and they are long. And this one does include the Four Noble Truths. So this is something that you very rarely get — they are presumed in all the literature that you read, that the Four Noble Truths are there at the basis. But here we've actually got what the Buddha meant by those Four Noble Truths.

Now as I say what the Buddha meant and what's actually written here — they've obviously been formalised. So in the earlier part of the scriptures it's much more informal, the way he's teaching. By this time everything's been formalised into lists and so forth. So I'll read through these Four Noble Truths. This is, remember, in the section on *dhmma*, which is translated as mind objects, but I think to be closer to the mark when we talk about the teachings.

So again, a meditator abides contemplating mind objects. And how does he do this? He does in respect to the Four Noble Truths. "This is suffering," he knows it as it really is. "This is the origin of suffering," he knows it as it really is. "This is the cessation of suffering," he knows as it really is. "And this is the way of practice leading to the cessation of suffering."

And what is this Noble Truth of Suffering? Birth is suffering. Ageing is suffering. Death is suffering. Sorrow, lamentation, pain, sadness and distress are suffering. Being attached to the unloved is suffering. Being separated from the loved is suffering. Not getting what one wants is suffering. In short, the five aggregates of grasping are suffering.

So then there are definitions of these. For instance, what is birth? Whatever beings of whatever group of beings — there is birth, coming to be, coming forth, the appearance of the aggregates. So that's a psychophysical organism — the acquisition of the sense spaces, the six sense bases including the mind. This is called birth.

Ageing: whatever beings of whatever group of beings — that is ageing, decrepitude, broken teeth, grey

hair, wrinkled skin, shrinking with age, decay of sense faculties. This is called ageing. He's not bad, is he? He's got it nailed there, I think.

And what is death? Whatever beings of whatever group of beings — passing away, a removal, a cutting off, a disappearance, a death, a dying, an ending, a cutting off of the aggregates, a psychophysical organism, discarding of the body. This is death.

So then he describes these words that he's used. What is sorrow? So any kind of misfortune anyone is affected by something of a painful nature — sorrow, mourning, distress, inward grief, inward woe. That is called sorrow.

Lamentation: whatever, any kind of misfortune, anyone is affected by something of a painful nature and there is crying out, lamenting, making much noise of grief, making great lamentation. This is called lamentation.

What is pain? Whatever bodily painful feeling, bodily unpleasant feeling, painful or unpleasant feelings result from bodily contact. This is called pain. Always says body — of course it's the whole body, the whole senses, everything.

What is sadness? Whatever mental painful feeling, mental unpleasant feeling, painful or unpleasant sensation results in mental contact. This is called sadness.

And distress: whatever kind of misfortune anyone is affected by something of a painful nature — distress, great distress, affliction with distress, with great distress. This is called distress.

And what is being attached to the unloved? Here, whoever has unwanted, disliked, unpleasant sight objects, sounds, smells, tastes, tangibles or mental objects, or whoever encounters ill-wishers, wishes of harm, of discomfort, insecurity, with whom they have concourse, connection, union. This is called attached to the unloved. In other words, when you're stuck with some situation which is highly unpleasant or some person whom you find unpleasant.

And what is the separation from the loved? Here, whoever has what is wanted, liked, pleasant sight objects, sounds, smells, tastes, tangibles and mind objects, and whoever encounters well-wishers, wishes of good, of comfort, of security — mother or father, brother or sister, or younger kinsmen, or friends, or colleagues, or blood relations — and then is deprived of concourse, connection, and union. That is called separation from the loved.

So he's now described those little adjectives that come at the end of the noble truths. And then he says, what is not getting what one wants? So this is the crux of it, isn't it? In being subject to birth, this wish arises: "Oh, that we were not subject to birth, that we might not come to birth." But this cannot be gained by wishing. This is not getting what one wants. In being subject to ageing, to disease, to death, to sorrow, lamentation, pain, sadness and distress, this wish arises: "Oh, that we were not subject to ageing," and so

forth. But this cannot be gained by wishing. This is not getting what one wants.

And how, monks, in short, are the five aggregates of grasping suffering? The aggregates of grasping: form, feeling, perception, mental formations and consciousness. These, in short, are the five aggregates of grasping.

So now, remember the Buddha has this cross section of human beings where there's the body, which includes the senses, all the senses, including the mind — the mental base. And then there are all the feelings, both physical and mental feelings that we have in the body. There's all the perception, which then grows into concepts and all that. And when these two things are joined, feeling and perception, that's when we start creating these habits — mental habits, physical habits. And all that has to appear upon a screen of consciousness.

Now, all that the Buddha did after his awakening — nothing changed at that level. He had a body, he was feeling things, he had perceptions and concepts. I mean all his teaching is a psychological philosophy or an ethical philosophy. And he, of course, he's conscious. So nothing has changed. What has changed is the grasping. That's the one thing that's changed.

What is this grasping? His identity. So we did all that at the beginning of this series, if you remember, about the self. It's identifying with this form that creates the initial problem. Because with this being me, I'm trying to chase happiness with it. And either I'm getting it and it disappears just when I've got it, or it never stays long enough, or I'm stuck in a situation which is unpleasant. So chasing happiness from the point of view of a self is a fool's game. So that's this whole business of letting go. But we've come to that — we're coming to that.

So now the next Noble Truth, of course, is the origin of suffering. It is that very craving which gives rise to rebirth, bound up with pleasure and lust, finding fresh delight now here, now there — that is to say, sensual craving, craving for existence, and craving for non-existence.

So if you think about what it is that we crave for — this craving is again a desire. The way they translate these two words, *tanha* and *upadāna* — so *tanha* is your initial desire, which can be a craving, unfortunately. And the *upadāna* is the craving which comes about by identification. So I would always prefer to translate them as desire, wrong desire, craving and identifying, possessing, possessing and identifying.

So basically the cause, the cause of everything, is this relationship of wanting happiness from or through this psychophysical organism. And where does this craving arise and establish itself? Wherever in the world there is anything agreeable or pleasant, there this craving arises and establishes itself.

And what is there in the world that is agreeable and pleasurable? Now remember, when he's talking about the world at this level, it's not the objective world out there. It's the world we're creating. And the world we're creating, of course, is often dependent on information from the outside world, but it's still our

world. It's still our little universe.

So, and what is there in the world that is agreeable and pleasant? Well, anything to do with the eye, the ear, the nose, the tongue and so forth — that's where craving arises and establishes itself. Sights, sounds, smells, tastes, tangibles and mind objects in the world are agreeable and pleasurable, and there this craving arises and establishes itself.

It's obvious that when he says "the world" he really means — sometimes he talks about "in this fathom-length body." And of course it establishes itself also in consciousness. And then there's a whole section here which touches upon dependent origination. We won't go into that because it's a bit too long, but it's about the initial contact, the feeling that he's got from contact. So your contact may be with a friend, the feeling comes of happiness. Perception — so we have perceptions which then tend to develop into concepts. Then there's the will, the wanting, the desire, the volition. And then there's this craving, which is — volition is the energy needed for something to happen. Then there's the craving, and then there's thinking — they've translated it as thinking and pondering. This is Maurice Walsh, who's died — well, he died a while back actually — thinking and pondering. So basically it's your initial ideas and how you're developing them. And of course, all this happens in the objects in the world that are agreeable and pleasurable.

Now, having established the fact that the real fundamental problem that creates all this dissatisfaction, suffering and so forth for us, is this desire, this wrong type of desire, he then, of course, can make the statement that is the Noble Truth of the cessation of suffering. It is the complete fading away and extinction of this craving. This very craving is forsaking and abandonment, liberation from it and detachment from it. And how does this craving come to be abandoned? How does this cessation come to be?

In other words, our practice is renunciation. So it's not — remember it's not self-mortification, not trying to punish ourselves, definitely not trying to punish the body. The body's just doing its thing. It's this constant effort to see where there's a wrong desire and just hold it there, not activate upon it, let it arise and pass away. And every time we experience that and the release, the relief, the unshackling from that desire and the little bit of joy that arises — even if it's just that lovely equanimity that arises, the peacefulness of a mind which is not agitated, turbulent with desire — that's a little sneaky preview of *Nibbāna*.

Whatever is agreeable — let's take a look now. Then he goes through, you know, the consciousness, the eye consciousness and all that, through all the sights and sounds and so forth. Letting go of all that, of contact. And then finally, that is the cessation of suffering.

And what, monks, is the Noble Truth — so this I'm sure you all know, but even so — right view. What is right view? Well, it is the knowledge of this suffering, the knowledge of the reason or the cause of suffering, the knowledge of the cessation of suffering, and this very practice leading to that cessation.

The next one, of course, is right attitude. *Samma sankappa* — some people translate it as right motive, but I just prefer the word attitude. So it's thoughts of ill will — it's actually an attitude of letting go of things, letting go of that desire. Thoughts of non-ill will, which is, of course, everything that you don't want to do in order to establish love. And thoughts of harmlessness, which, of course, is just another way of saying compassion. So when he says thoughts of renunciation, it's also a way of saying generosity. So these things always move towards their opposite.

See, the more you let go of things, the more you're happy to give. And the more you let go of ill will and hatred and all that silly stuff, the more you are able to love. And the more you let go of harmfulness, harmful thoughts, wishing somebody ill, and the more obviously there's compassion — because all this negative stuff is always being transformed. You don't lose anything. It's just energy. It's just energy. It's just thinking and all that. And it's just slowly transforming towards their opposites.

What is right speech? So he always tells us what we shouldn't be doing first. So it's refraining from lying, from slander, from harsh speech — there's a better word than harsh speech. Abusive. Abusive speech is a much better translation — refraining from frivolous speech as well. But then, of course, as you let go of that, you move towards gentle, truthful, at the right time, and with the heart of loving-kindness. So your speech is coming from a different sense — it's coming from the good heart.

What, monks, is right action? Refraining from taking life, from taking what is not given, from refraining from sexual misconduct. So obviously, if we stop taking life, then we move towards preserving it. If you stop taking what is not freely given, you move towards generosity. And now this *kama* is always translated as sexual misconduct, but it has a wider meaning of indulging the senses. But here, refraining from sexual misconduct — obviously the proper place for erotic rather than sexual conduct is within a fulsome relationship.

And then, what is right livelihood? Well, it basically says to give up wrong livelihood — so any livelihood that does harm — and to have right livelihood. Now, this is an important thing, because I remember my teacher saying that wasn't necessary because it's included really in right action. But even so, he makes it a special category. And when you think that you spend a lot of your energy — we spend a lot of our energy on the work we do — you can see that it has an effect upon us.

So if you're in the caring professions, then obviously you're developing that sense of care, the sense of compassion. If you're in, say, policing, then again, you're there with a sense of protecting, of trying to stop harm. So that also is compassion. Although it makes you very suspicious, I think. So whatever livelihood you're undertaking, it will have an effect on your character, on the way you experience life.

Then the last three — by the way, often, remember, the Eightfold Path is put as *sīla*, *samādhi*, *paññā*, which is morality, meditation and wisdom. It mixes it the other way around. But as it's laid out by the Buddha, it's wisdom and then right conduct and then finally the meditation.

So right effort: arouses his will, makes an effort, stirs up energy, exerts his mind and strives to prevent the arising of unarisen, evil, unwholesome mental states. In other words, to stop naughty things arising in the mind. He arouses his will and so forth and strives to overcome evil unwholesome mental states. So as soon as something that you see is unwholesome comes up, then there's the effort to not enjoy it, not develop it, not express it. And then he arouses his will, makes an effort, stirs up energy, exerts his mind and strives to maintain wholesome mental states that have arisen and not let them fade away. And he does the same — hold on — he arouses to produce unarisen wholesome states. In other words, always having right intentions which bring up wholesome mental states. And when they arise, to do our best to maintain them.

And what, monks, is right mindfulness? And now I did say this was about meditation, but obviously the effort is there in the whole of the path. What we do, our livelihoods and so forth. Right mindfulness is also throughout the day — it's not just when we're sitting. But here it's basically meant as only the meditation, when we're sitting.

So that puts us right mindfulness and right concentration. Here it's really only expressed as the *jhāna*, these absorption states, but obviously in all of our daily life, it's keeping your attention on what you're doing.

So then the usual refrain: that he contemplates mind objects as mind objects internally and externally — both. So you can see them in other people, these things that you can see, these attitudes and what they're doing and so forth. He abides contemplating the arising of mind objects. He abides contemplating the vanishing. So it's the arising and vanishing, both the arising and vanishing.

So it's always about seeing process, about seeing that nothing remains, nothing's reliable. Or just this bare attentiveness, as they put it, of something which arises within our consciousness, and just enough so that insight and awareness can arise.

And he abides detached—that should be, see, that's the old way of saying it. You see, this was published in, I don't know, I think it's the 1890s or something. And that was the old way of expressing this detachment. Now they say non-attachment. It's non-dual, right? It's neither attachment nor detachment. It's non-attachment.

And monks, this is how you abide. Or meditators, this is how you abide, contemplating mind objects. So that completes all these mind objects, the last section, the fourth section of the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse.

But then there's this lovely ending, this conclusion, which hopefully raises possibilities for us. Whoever should practice these four foundations of mindfulness for just seven years may expect one of two results: either *arahatship*—complete liberation from all suffering and the awakening—or if there is some substrate left, they haven't quite made it, then the state of *non-returner*. Now the non-returner is that person who is no longer attracted to the sensual life, right? They've gone beyond, but they've not gone so

beyond that they're fully liberated.

Let alone seven years. Whoever should practice it for just six years, five years, four years, three years, two years, one year may expect one of two results. Never mind one year. Whoever practices for seven months, six months, five months, four months, three months, two months, one month, half a month, may expect one of two results.

And whoever practices this even for one week can expect one of two results, either full liberation or with the substrate left as a non-returner. And now it was said, this is... And so then having said that, he repeats the original statement that he makes right at the beginning of the discourse.

How could you possibly be fully liberated in one week? You see, we do have occasions in the scripture where people wake up just like that. I might bring—there's the very famous, or well-known case rather, of Bāhiya the bark-cloak, where he basically gives him a few hints and he becomes fully liberated right there and then. There's not time to go into that at the moment.

So this one week—one presumes that that means that from the moment you get up on Monday morning until you fall asleep the next Sunday evening, that you haven't lost your mindfulness even for one second, right? Then we can expect some results. So that's what we're working towards.

And so finally, this monks, this is the one way. Remember, this is... they've translated *ekayāno* in various ways, but the one that I prefer is that this is the path of pure *vipassanā* as opposed to the path where you practice these absorptions and *vipassanā*. So this is the one way, path of pure *vipassanā*: purification of beings, for the overcoming of sorrow and distress, for the disappearance of pain and sadness, for the gaining of the right path, for the realization of *Nibbāna*—that is to say, the four foundations of mindfulness. And it is for this reason that it has been spoken.

Thus spoke the Lord, and the listeners, the monks and everybody else rejoiced and were delighted at his words, as I'm sure we are too.

So that brings to an end our run through the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse on how to establish right mindfulness. As I say, there are now excellent books on it which you can read, and you'll find them on the website there, on resources.

So, oh, time moves on. I trust my words have been of some assistance, not caused too much confusion. May you, by your continuous efforts and practice, achieve full liberation sooner rather than later.

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